Conditionals: zero, first, second, third, mixed, inverted / unless, in case, as/so long as, provided (that)

Zero conditional

Form *if* + present simple, present simple

Use	Example
General or scientific facts and definitions	*If you **have** faith in something, you **believe** in something you cannot prove.*

First conditional

Form *if* + a present tense, *will* + bare infinitive

Use	Example
Real or likely conditions in the present or future and their results in the present and future	*If you **have** a birthday party, you'**ll get** loads of cool presents!*
	*If you'**re working** till half past six, we'**ll have** dinner at about eight.*
	*If you **have revised** properly, you **won't have** any problems in the test next week.*

Watch out!

- We can also use *may, might, can, could, shall, should, ought to, have to* instead of *will*, depending on the meaning.
  ✓ *If you **have** a birthday party, you **might get** loads of cool presents!*
- We can also use *should* + bare infinitive instead of present simple. This suggests the situation is possible, but unlikely to happen.
  ✓ *If you **should bump** into Alex at the concert, you'll be able to get a lift home.*
- We can also use a form of the first conditional to give instructions about real or likely situations in the present or future. This is: *if* + a present tense, imperative.
  ✓ *If you **decide** to have a birthday party, **tell** me!*

unless, in case, as/so long as, provided (that)

Word or Phrase	Meaning	Example
unless	'except if' or 'if…not'	*I'll be there at six **unless** I get delayed.* (= except if I get delayed / if I don't get delayed)
in case	'because he/she/it/etc might'	*Let's take our wellies **in case** it's muddy.* (= because it might be muddy)
as/so long as	'if' or 'only if'	***As long as** I'm happy, my parents don't care what job I do.* ***So long as** I'm happy, my parents don't care what job I do.*
provided (that)	'if' or 'only if'	***Provided (that)** I'm happy, my parents don't care what job I do.*

Second conditional

Form *if* + past simple or past continuous, *would* + bare infinitive

Use	Example
Impossible, unlikely or hypothetical conditions in the present or future and their results in the present or future	*If you **had** a beard, you **would look** just like Charles Dickens!* *If you **were flying** to Rio, **would** you **get** there much quicker?*
Advice	*If I **were** you, I would think very carefully about my future.* (more formal) *If I **was** you, I'd have a party at the weekend!* (more informal)

Watch out!

- We can also use *might* or *could* instead of *would*, depending on the meaning. (Note: *could* here often means *would be able to*.)
  ✓ *If we **were** older, we **could go** on holiday on our own.*
- We can also use *could* in the *if* clause. Here, it means *was/were able to*.
  ✓ *If I **could** drive, I'd buy a car.*

Third conditional

Form	*if* + past perfect (simple or continuous), *would* + *have* + past participle
Use	**Example**
Hypothetical conditions in the past and their results in the past	*If you **had worn** a fake beard, no one **would have known** who you were!* (= You didn't wear a fake beard so people knew who you were.) *If she**'d been wearing** her new glasses, I **would have noticed** them.* (= She wasn't wearing her new glasses so I didn't notice them.)

Watch out!

- We can also use *might, could* or *should* instead of *would*, depending on the meaning.
  ✓ *If I **had done** some revision, I **might / could / should** have passed the exam.*

Mixed conditionals

Form	*if* + past perfect (simple or continuous), *would* + bare infinitive
Use	**Example**
Hypothetical past condition and a present result	*If I **had listened** to my parents, I **wouldn't be** in so much trouble now.* (= I didn't listen to my parents so I'm in lots of trouble now.)

Form	*if* + past simple or past continuous, *would* + *have* + past participle
Use	**Example**
Hypothetical present condition and a past result	*If I **had** a mobile, I **would have called** you last night.* (= I don't have a mobile so I didn't call you last night.)

Inverted conditionals

Form	*Should I/you/he/etc* ... instead of *If I/you/he/etc should* ... *Were I/you/he/etc* ... instead of *If I/you/he/etc were* ... *Had I/you/he/etc* ... instead of *If I/you/he/etc had* ...
Use	**Example**
More formal form of the first conditional (with *should*)	***Should** the situation worsen, the United Nations is prepared to send in a peacekeeping force.* (= If the situation should worsen...)
More formal form of the second conditional	***Were** the situation to worsen, the United Nations would be prepared to send in a peacekeeping force.* (= If the situation were to worsen...)
More formal form of the third conditional	***Had** the situation worsened, the United Nations would have been prepared to send in a peacekeeping force.* (= If the situation had worsened...)

Watch out!

- For all conditional sentences (first, second, third, mixed, inverted), when the condition comes before the result it is usually followed by a comma. When the result comes first, no comma is necessary.
  ✓ *If I had a mobile, I would have called you last night.*
  ✓ *I would have called you last night if I had a mobile.*
- In conditional sentences, modals (*will, would, could*, etc) are sometimes followed by a continuous infinitive.
  ✓ *We**'d** still **be waiting** if you hadn't turned up.*

US vs UK Grammar

- With second and third conditionals in informal conversation, speakers of American English sometimes use *would* or *would have* in the *if* clause. This is very unusual in British English.
  US: *How would you feel if this **happened / would happen** to you?*
  UK: *How would you feel if this **happened** to you?*
  US: *I would have felt awful if that **had happened / would have happened** to me.*
  UK: *I would have felt awful if that **had happened** to me.*

A Write *Yes* or *No* to answer the questions about each sentence.

1 If Carl doesn't come to the party, I'll be really upset.
Is it possible that Carl won't come to the party? .....

2 If my neighbour became prime minister, he'd give everyone a million euros.
Is it likely that the neighbour will become prime minister? .....
Is it possible that the neighbour will become prime minister? .....

3 If Helen weren't here, I don't know what we'd do.
Is Helen here now? .....

4 If Tarek had had enough money, he'd have bought a car.
Did Tarek have enough money? .....
Did he buy a car? .....

5 If Debbie hadn't gone to the UK, she wouldn't have met Will.
Did Debbie go to the UK? .....
Did she meet Will? .....

6 If the police had investigated the case thoroughly, they wouldn't have arrested Keren.
Did the police investigate the case thoroughly? .....
Did they arrest Keren? .....

7 Had she not gone to university, she might not have started her own business.
Did she go to university? .....
Did she start her own business? .....

B Complete the definitions using your own ideas.

Example:
If you trust someone, you believe that they won't let you down.

1 If you bully someone, ...
2 If you accuse someone, ...
3 If you are a liar, ...
4 If you are rich, ...
5 If you are lucky, ...
6 If you are lazy, ...
7 If you look up to someone, ...
8 If you look down on someone, ...

C Complete using the correct form of the verbs in the box.

be • call • find • forget • get • leave • see • take • want • work

1 If she ..... at five o'clock, she'll be there by half past seven.
2 We ..... you if we have any problems.
3 It might not be a good idea to go out tonight if you ..... an important test in the morning.
4 If you ..... ill all day, you shouldn't come to the club tonight.
5 If you should ..... my wallet, call me on my mobile immediately!
6 Let's get a different DVD if you ..... that one already.
7 If Sean ..... so hard lately, he'll welcome the chance to have a few days off.
8 If you're going into town, ... a video for tonight while you're there!
9 If you see Carol tonight, ... to say hello from me!
10 Don't feel you have to come if you ..... to.

D Circle the correct word or phrase.

1 This time in six months I'll be at university **unless / if** I decide to take a year off first.
2 We'd better leave early tomorrow **unless / in case** there's a lot of traffic when we get to Doncaster.
3 You can watch the film **as long as / in case** you promise to go straight to bed when it finishes.
4 Let's go to *Mirabella's* tonight **unless / if** you haven't been there before.
5 **Unless / So long as** I've still got my health, I don't mind how poor I am!
6 You'd better take a sweater with you now **if / in case** it gets cold tonight.
7 Do what you like **provided / unless** you don't make any noise.
8 I'm not going to worry **unless / as long as** she hasn't called by midnight.

E Write sentences using the second conditional.

Example: I don't want to buy that CD so I'm not going to.
If I wanted to buy that CD, I would. .....

1 I don't live alone so I don't get lonely.
.....
2 Don's got such a lot of homework that he's not going to play football tonight.
.....
3 I can't swim so I'm not going scuba diving with Terry.
.....
4 We're not going to order a pizza because we don't have enough money.
.....
5 We're not staying in the same hotel, so we can't share a room.
.....
6 I'm not you, but I think you should call Antony right now!
.....
7 I can't come because I have to help my dad with something.
.....
8 I don't go to bed as late as you so I'm able to get up early in the morning.
.....

F Read the text and complete the sentences using the third conditional.

Some scientists, such as Stephen Hawking, believe it's possible that there are billions and billions of universes. Each universe has a different possible consequence for every action. In the universe we live in, for example, George Bush became President of the USA in January 2001, and Greece won the European Cup in July 2004. But in other universes different things happened. Imagine if that's true! In some universes, your parents didn't meet, so you weren't born. In another universe, a meteor didn't strike the Earth, so the dinosaurs didn't become extinct. In a different universe, your best friend won the lottery last summer and moved to a bigger house. In another parallel universe, you started learning English a year earlier, so you did this book last year! Somewhere else, Madonna wasn't discovered, and so didn't make any records. In another universe, Van Gogh was recognised as a great painter during his lifetime, and so didn't die in poverty. And perhaps in several universes, there were enough lifeboats on the *Titanic* and so everyone on board survived. It makes you think, doesn't it?

1 If I'd started learning English a year earlier, ...
2 If a meteor hadn't struck the Earth, ...
3 If my best friend had won the lottery last summer, ...
4 If my parents .....
5 Everyone on board the *Titanic* .....
6 Van Gogh .....
7 Madonna .....
8 If George Bush .....
9 If Greece .....

G Choose the correct answer.

If this theory about parallel universes (**1**) ..... correct, it (**2**) ..... that we're living in more than one universe at the same time. But if that (**3**) ..... true – if I was doing different things in different universes – (**4**) ..... about it. And if I (**5**) ..... about it, how could it be me doing these things? If I (**6**) ..... the lottery last year in a parallel universe, and decided to sail round the world, how is that 'me'? It doesn't make sense!
And another thing. If I do something, it (**7**) ..... consequences. For example, if I (**8**) ..... study, I might not pass my exams. I can't start thinking about different universes where the consequences are different. If I just (**9**) ..... about the universe I actually live in, then I'm sure (**10**) ..... okay!

1	A will be	B is	C would have been	D has been
2	A has meant	B meant	C had meant	D means
3	A will be	B was being	C were	D has been
4	A I'd know	B I'll know	C I have known	D I know
5	A wouldn't know	B don't know	C won't know	D didn't know
6	A had won	B was winning	C have won	D win
7	A would have	B would have had	C will have	D had had
8	A won't	B haven't	C don't	D hadn't
9	A think	B to think	C am thinking	D have thought
10	A I'd be	B I've been	C I'd have been	D I'll be

H Complete using the correct form of the verbs in brackets.

1 If ..... (**you / do**) your homework last night, you'd know the answer to this question!
2 We ..... (**not / stand**) by the side of the road at the moment trying to get a lift if ..... (**we / bring**) a spare tyre with us.
3 If I ..... (**not / stay up**) so late last night, I ..... (**not / feel**) so tired this morning!
4 ..... (**I / be**) in terrible trouble right now if you ..... (**not / help**) me.
5 If I had a video recorder, ... (**I / record**) the match last night.
6 ..... (**I / ask**) for Andy's phone number when I met him if I ..... (**not / already / have**) a boyfriend!

7 If Cody ..... (**not / live**) so far away, he ..... (**not / be**) so late to the barbecue yesterday.

8 Tracy ..... (**not / need**) extra lessons last month if she ..... (**be**) as good at maths as you are.

9 ..... (**you / got**) a job when you left school if the university ..... (**not / offer**) you a place?

10 If you ..... (**have**) as much money as she does, ... (**you / retire**) by now?

I Complete the sentences so that the meaning remains the same.

1 If her condition should improve, we'll inform you immediately.
Should .....

2 Jade will ask lots of difficult questions if she gets to interview a famous politician.
Should .....

3 If you were able to go abroad for the summer, where would you go?
Were .....

4 If I was to become a vet, I'd find putting animals down very difficult.
Were .....

5 The world would be much better off if all environmental pollution stopped today.
Were .....

6 If the hole in the ozone layer had been discovered sooner, fewer people would have got skin cancer.
Had .....

7 I wouldn't have become a teacher if I hadn't had such a good English teacher at school.
Had .....

J If a line is correct, put a tick (✓) next to the number. If there is an extra word in a line, write it next to the number.

Being an only child

1 ..... I'm an only child. People often say to me: 'Wouldn't you be a lot
2 ..... happier if you have had brothers and sisters?' but I don't see it like that.
3 ..... It's true that if I had had a brother or sister, I would have someone closer
4 ..... to my own age to talk to and play with at home, but I don't think that's
5 ..... very important provided for you have close friends, which I do. If my
6 ..... parents would had more children, they wouldn't be able to spend so much
7 ..... time with me. And we have great fun together! Also, except if I had a
8 ..... brother or sister, I'd have it to share a bedroom with them. That might be
9 ..... fun, but what would happen if I wanted to play my CDs and he or she had
10 ..... to study? No – I don't want a brother or sister, unless it will happens, of
course. In that case, I'll think it's the best thing in the world!